

KoboToolbox

Researcher Setup & Usage Guide

Everything you need to set up, deploy, share, and manage your survey

Prepared for researchers using custom KoboToolbox survey forms

SECTION 1: Creating Your KoboToolbox Account

Before you can use your survey form, you need a free KoboToolbox account. Follow these steps:

Step 1: Go to the KoboToolbox website

Open your browser and go to: <https://kf.kobotoolbox.org>

Step 2: Create a free account

Click 'Create an Account'. Enter your name, email address, and a password. Choose the FREE Humanitarian server — this is sufficient for academic research.

Step 3: Verify your email

Check your email inbox for a verification link from KoboToolbox. Click it to activate your account.

Step 4: Log in

Return to <https://kf.kobotoolbox.org> and log in with your email and password.

 **Tip:** Use your institutional email address (e.g. university email) for credibility when sharing the survey with respondents.

SECTION 2: Uploading Your Survey Form

You have been provided with a ready-made survey form as an Excel (.xlsx) file. Here is how to upload it:

Step 1: Click 'NEW' button

On your KoboToolbox dashboard, click the blue NEW button on the top left.

Step 2: Select 'Upload an XLSForm'

From the options that appear, choose 'Upload an XLSForm'.

Step 3: Upload your file

Click 'Choose File' and select the .xlsx file you were provided. Then click 'Upload'.

Step 4: Wait for processing

KoboToolbox will process the file. This takes a few seconds. You will see your form appear on the dashboard.

Step 5: Check the form

Click on the form name, then click the 'FORM' tab to preview all questions and make sure everything looks correct.

 **Note:** Do NOT edit the Excel file before uploading unless you have been instructed to. Changing column names or structure will break the form.

SECTION 3: Deploying Your Form

Deploying makes your form live and ready to collect responses. A form in 'Draft' status cannot receive responses.

Step 1: Open your form

Click on the form name from your dashboard.

Step 2: Click 'Deploy'

You will see a yellow banner at the top saying the form is undeployed. Click the 'Deploy' button.

Step 3: Confirm deployment

A popup will appear asking you to confirm. Click 'Deploy' again.

Step 4: Form is now live

Your form status will change from 'Draft' to 'Deployed'. You are now ready to share it.

 **Tip:** Every time you make changes to a deployed form, you must re-deploy for the changes to take effect.

SECTION 4: Sharing the Survey with Respondents

There are two ways to share your survey with respondents:

Option A — Share the Web Link (Recommended)

Step 1: Go to FORM tab

Click on your form, then click the 'FORM' tab at the top.

Step 2: Click 'Collect Data'

You will see a link that looks like: <https://ee.kobotoolbox.org/x/xxxxxxx>

Step 3: Copy and share the link

Copy this link and send it to your respondents via WhatsApp, email, or any messaging platform. Anyone with the link can fill the form — they do NOT need a KoboToolbox account.

 **Tip:** Shorten the link using bit.ly or tinyurl.com to make it easier to share, especially via WhatsApp.

Option B — Offline Collection Using KoboCollect App

For areas with poor internet connectivity, respondents can use the KoboCollect Android app:

- Respondents download the free KoboCollect app from Google Play Store
- They configure it with your server URL: <https://kf.kobotoolbox.org>
- They fill the form offline on their phone
- When internet is available, responses sync automatically to your dashboard

 **Note:** KoboCollect is only available on Android phones. For iPhone users, the web link (Option A) works on any browser.

SECTION 5: Monitoring Responses

Once respondents start filling the form, you can monitor responses in real time from your dashboard.

Step 1: Go to DATA tab

Click on your form, then click the 'DATA' tab at the top.

Step 2: View Table

Click 'Table' on the left side to see all submitted responses in a spreadsheet format.

Step 3: View Reports

Click 'Reports' to see automatic charts and summaries of your data.

Step 4: View Map

If your form collected GPS data, click 'Map' to see where responses came from geographically.

 **Tip:** Refresh the page to see the latest responses. KoboToolbox updates in real time as submissions come in.

SECTION 6: Downloading Your Data

When you are ready to analyse your data, download it in your preferred format:

Step 1: Go to DATA tab

Click on your form, then click the 'DATA' tab.

Step 2: Click Downloads

Click 'Downloads' on the left side panel.

Step 3: Select format

Choose your preferred format: • XLS / Excel — for cleaning and viewing in Excel • CSV — for SPSS, R, or Stata • SPSS — direct SPSS format (saves conversion time)

Step 4: Click Export

Click 'Export' and wait for the file to be prepared. Then click 'Download' when it appears.

 **Tip:** For SPSS analysis, download in SPSS format directly — it saves you the step of importing and coding manually.

SECTION 7: Understanding Your Dashboard

Here is a quick reference guide to what each tab in KoboToolbox does:

Tab	What it does
SUMMARY	Shows total responses, response rate, and quick statistics at a glance
FORM	Preview your form, get the shareable link, and manage form versions
DATA → Table	See all individual responses in a spreadsheet format
DATA → Reports	Automatic charts and frequency tables for each question
DATA → Gallery	View any photos or media submitted by respondents
DATA → Downloads	Export your data to Excel, CSV, SPSS, or other formats
DATA → Map	See geographic distribution of responses (if GPS was collected)
SETTINGS	Manage form sharing, permissions, and language settings

SECTION 8: Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Do my respondents need a KoboToolbox account?

No. Respondents only need the link you share with them. They open it in any browser and fill the form without creating an account.

Q: Can multiple respondents fill the form at the same time?

Yes. KoboToolbox handles unlimited simultaneous responses. There is no limit on how many people can fill your form at once.

Q: What happens if a respondent loses internet while filling the form?

If using the web link, their progress may be lost. For areas with poor connectivity, use KoboCollect app (Section 4, Option B) which works fully offline.

Q: Can I edit the form after deployment?

Yes, but you must re-deploy after making changes. Note that changing question names may affect previously collected data.

Q: How do I know if someone submitted a response?

Go to DATA → Table. Each row is one completed submission. The number of submissions is also shown on your dashboard.

Q: Is my data secure?

Yes. KoboToolbox uses secure servers and your data is only visible to you unless you explicitly share access with someone else.

Q: How do I delete a test response?

Go to DATA → Table, click the eye icon next to the test response, then click Delete Submission.

SECTION 9: Quick Reference Checklist

Use this checklist to make sure you have completed every step before launching your survey:

- ✓ Created KoboToolbox account at kf.kobotoolbox.org
- ✓ Uploaded the provided .xlsx form file
- ✓ Previewed the form to confirm all questions are correct
- ✓ Deployed the form (status shows 'Deployed', not 'Draft')
- ✓ Copied the shareable link from FORM → Collect Data
- ✓ Tested the form yourself by filling it once
- ✓ Deleted your test response from DATA → Table
- ✓ Shared the link with your respondents
- ✓ Monitoring responses from DATA → Table
- ✓ Downloaded data when collection is complete

Need further assistance? Contact your form provider.

Thank you for choosing *The Postgraduate Data Hub, Kenya.*

Kenya's home for postgraduate research support — from questionnaire design to Chapter 4 analysis and beyond.

Stuck at any step? We are one message away.

— GET IN TOUCH

Reach us anytime



EMAIL

postgraduatedatahub@gmail.com



WHATSAPP

+254 779 568 272



WEBSITE

postgrad-hub-1.vercel.app

— WHAT WE OFFER

- Questionnaire and interview guide refinement
- SPSS Academy — step-by-step lessons using Kenyan case studies
- Chapter 4 data analysis, tables, and figures
- Reliability tests, correlation, regression, ANOVA — and more
- One-on-one consultations for postgraduate students